# Asaf Jahi Hyderabad: Archival Chronology, Institutions and Unequal Modernisation

**Paper II / Unit II / Topic 3 — Original gap-focused supplementary research, 26 October 2026.**

**Status: draft requiring independent academic review.** This supplement complements, and does not replace, the earlier tenure/Vetti repair or the published original topic PDF. All questions below are original practice, **not verified official TGPSC PYQs**. Exact source page references are maintained in the editorial audit, not asserted as student-facing evidence.

## Syllabus alignment

Establishment of the Asaf Jahi dynasty; Salar Jung's reforms; socio-economic conditions, land tenures, jagirdars, deshmukhs and vetti; British paramountcy; 1857 in Hyderabad and Turre Baz Khan; sixth/seventh Nizams; railways, communications, industries, education and monuments. Focus of this supplement: documentary chronology, institutional mechanisms, regional differentiation and conflicting interpretations.

## 1. Reading Hyderabad through three kinds of evidence

A study of the Asaf Jahi state must distinguish a ruler's legal claim, the machinery through which the claim was exercised, and the experience of subjects. A treaty may say who controlled external relations; a revenue manual may classify a village; a petition may reveal that cultivators understood those rules very differently. These are not interchangeable sources. For the eighteenth century, court chronicles and Company correspondence are especially prominent, but both reflect interested institutions. For the nineteenth century, administrative reports and treaty collections permit a closer view of fiscal and departmental change. For the twentieth century, university records, industrial company histories and urban public-works documentation help test the rhetoric of modernisation.

This method corrects a frequent exam error: treating a monument, an official proclamation and a social outcome as equivalent evidence. The opening of a school proves an institutional initiative; it does not by itself establish literacy among landless girls. Similarly, a railway timetable can document a route, not the distribution of gains between merchants, miners and peasants. For each claim ask four questions: who produced the record, when, for what administrative or political purpose, and what independent source could contradict it? The outcome is a historical explanation that can acknowledge reform without hiding coercion.

## 2. From Mughal office to Deccan sovereignty: the problem of 1724

Mir Qamar-ud-din Khan's defeat of Mubariz Khan at Shakar Kheda in 1724 is a useful chronological anchor, but the event should not be mistaken for a declaration of complete independence in the twentieth-century sense. Asaf Jah I had acquired authority through Mughal offices and continued to use imperial idioms of legitimacy. The key change was effective command over revenue, military appointments and regional alliances as Delhi's ability to enforce orders weakened.

In the Deccan, autonomy was negotiated rather than simply announced. Maratha claims, regional noble houses, merchant finance and competing military forces shaped what the Nizam could actually collect and govern. The succession conflicts after Asaf Jah I's death in 1748 show the fragility of an order organised around a powerful individual. French and English companies supported rival factions, but Indian contenders actively sought those alliances. A mains answer should distinguish the date of a decisive victory, the continued use of Mughal legitimacy, and the much longer process of institutional consolidation. This prevents a neat but false narrative in which Hyderabad instantly became either fully independent or immediately subordinate to Britain.

## 3. Paramountcy as a changing bundle of constraints

British paramountcy over Hyderabad did not arise from one timeless treaty clause. Agreements in the late eighteenth and early nineteenth centuries altered military obligations, diplomatic freedom and fiscal arrangements. The 1798 and 1800 subsidiary-alliance settlements belong to a different stage from the 1853 Berar arrangement. The British Resident was influential because the Nizam's government increasingly depended on a military and diplomatic framework it could not independently control. Yet internal administration remained extensive.

The British Library's India Office Records catalogue identifies a 33-page file, IOR/L/PS/18/D8, containing treaties with Hyderabad extracted from Aitchison's collection for 1759–1861. The catalogue establishes that the archival source exists; it does not establish that every clause has been read in this production. Aitchison's 1864 fifth volume is also indexed by a Government of Maharashtra-supported digital collection. Until treaty text is checked directly, quote no invented clauses. Analyse the causal mechanism instead: external military dependence created fiscal obligations; fiscal disputes increased leverage over territories and policy; internal departments could nevertheless develop under the Nizam. This is constrained sovereignty, not straightforward annexation.

## 4. Berar, military finance and the limits of territorial labels

The Berar question illustrates why historians must separate legal title, revenue control and day-to-day administration. Financial obligations associated with the Hyderabad Contingent contributed to the 1853 assignment of Berar and other districts to British management. A later arrangement did not simply turn the entire Hyderabad State into a British province. The Nizam's continuing formal claims and British administrative control could coexist in different combinations over time.

Students sometimes memorise the phrase “cession of Berar” and then infer that sovereignty, ownership, fiscal rights and administration all transferred identically. That inference is unsafe. A better answer identifies the military cost that triggered the arrangement, the administrative powers exercised by the British and the distinction between Berar's history and that of Telugu-speaking Telangana districts. A map of Hyderabad at one date should not be used as evidence of its exact borders at another. In a source audit, treaty schedules and contemporaneous administrative maps are necessary before presenting precise territorial acreages. The larger lesson is that imperial power could operate through budgetary dependency as effectively as through open conquest.

## 5. A Hyderabad village had several overlapping authorities

In many rural settings the state demand, jagir privileges, hereditary revenue offices, landholding, moneylending and social rank overlapped. Khalsa or diwani lands under more direct administration should be distinguished from jagir assignments and the Nizam's Sarf-e-Khas domain. These categories changed over time and did not produce a uniform village experience. A jagirdar's rights could differ from those of a deshmukh who had acquired land and local influence through revenue service, credit and patronage. Patels and patwaris held village-level functions that affected measurement and records.

Consider a hypothetical cultivator disputing the entry for a tenancy plot. The record might be controlled by an official linked to a powerful household; the same household might also be a lender or employer. Even if the legal appeal was nominally available, the risk of losing credit or work could deter complaint. This is why administrative reform and social justice are analytically distinct. Reorganisation of departments might improve revenue regularity without removing local intimidation. The answer should identify specific mechanisms of dependence, not label every landholder identically “feudal.” A precise account compares formal entitlement, actual control of land, coercive capacity and avenues of redress.

## 6. Vetti: time, coercion and the political economy of dignity

Vetti was more than unpaid work measured in hours. Its defining feature was an obligation imposed through unequal power where refusal could invite punishment, loss of access to land, debt pressure or social exclusion. Demands might involve agricultural work, household service, carrying goods or duties for local officials. The burden was not uniform across communities, but caste and landlessness often made subordinated groups especially vulnerable. The opportunity cost was substantial: days spent in compulsory service were days not spent earning wages or cultivating one's own field.

The practice also reproduced social hierarchy by publicly demonstrating who could command another person's labour. A narrow revenue-history account misses this humiliation and gendered vulnerability. Yet a responsible historical account should not assert that every household in every Telangana village performed identical duties. Local petitions, village-level evidence and oral histories require triangulation. In a mains answer, connect vetti to land dependence, record control and political mobilisation, then distinguish abolition as a legal principle from actual enforcement. The agrarian protests of the twentieth century challenged an intertwined system of land, labour, coercion and status rather than a single isolated tax.

## 7. Salar Jung I: reform as a problem of state capacity

Salar Jung I served as Diwan from 1853 to 1883. The reform problem he inherited involved fragmented revenue authority, weak coordination across departments, fiscal stress and the pressure of British paramountcy. Reorganised district administration, more systematic accounts, judicial and police arrangements, public works and communications aimed to make rule more predictable and fiscally sustainable. These initiatives should be analysed as a connected programme: better records support assessment, regular accounts support budgeting, and transport enables officers and goods to move.

A reforming state, however, is not automatically a democratic or egalitarian state. Centralisation could reduce arbitrary interference from one set of courtiers while strengthening extraction from cultivators. New offices could create opportunities for educated employees without equal access for women, Dalits or remote villages. To evaluate Salar Jung, compare three outputs: administrative regularity, material infrastructure and the distribution of rights. Do not credit him personally with every institution founded decades after his death. Distinguish his tenure from the sixth Nizam's later reign and the seventh Nizam's twentieth-century projects. Chronological discipline prevents a list of achievements from becoming a false causal explanation.

## 8. The Residency attack of 17 July 1857: state policy versus dissent

Hyderabad's response to the uprising of 1857 reveals competing political positions within one princely state. The Nizam's government and Salar Jung I aligned with British power, while an armed group associated with Turre Baz Khan and Maulvi Alauddin attacked the British Residency on 17 July. The attack did not overturn the state government or produce a generalised takeover of Telangana. It nonetheless demonstrated that official diplomatic loyalty was not synonymous with unanimous popular acceptance of British rule.

Different evidence genres must be kept separate. A Residency dispatch might emphasise security threats; a later nationalist biography might highlight sacrifice; a local memorial might communicate public memory rather than a contemporaneous operational account. Without a certified original police file or dispatch, do not invent precise numbers of fighters, casualties, weapons or quotations. A nuanced exam answer explains the constraints on the Nizam's court, the motivations of dissenting groups, the limited immediate outcome and the later symbolic importance of Turre Baz Khan. The episode also exposes the danger of projecting a single all-India model of 1857 onto diverse princely-state settings.

## 9. The sixth and seventh Nizams must not be merged

Mir Mahbub Ali Khan, the sixth Nizam, and Mir Osman Ali Khan, the seventh, governed during different phases of administrative and technological change. The sixth Nizam's reign was associated with the consolidation of railway connections, urban institutions and professional administration. The seventh Nizam's reign saw major initiatives in higher education, water supply, flood mitigation, hospitals, industry and public architecture. Some projects originated in one period and matured in another; institutional chronology therefore matters more than attaching everything to one ruler.

Osmania University provides a useful warning. Its official history dates the founding firman to 26 April 1917, while the university's own milestones identify the launch of colleges in 1918. These dates describe different events and should not be treated as contradictory. Similarly, a public works project may have been proposed, financed, constructed and inaugurated in different years. For any achievement, identify which milestone is being dated. The social assessment must then ask who gained access: Hyderabad city's new middle classes, Urdu-literate students, industrial workers, rural tenants and women did not necessarily experience the same benefits.

## 10. Railways: connectivity, guaranteed finance and uneven gains

The Wadi–Secunderabad railway connection, conventionally dated to 1874, linked Hyderabad more closely to wider railway networks. Railways moved troops, coal, cotton, grain, officials and passengers; their significance was not merely technological. State guarantees and financing arrangements distributed risk among the Hyderabad government, private investors and imperial institutions. To judge their economic effect, a historian must ask which commodities moved, who paid freight, which markets gained access and whether remote villages received feeder roads.

The arrival of a railway station could raise demand for nearby land and facilitate trade while bypassing communities distant from the line. Railways also made coal mining more commercially viable, especially in the Yellandu–Singareni region. The railway and mining histories therefore intersect. Avoid claiming that every railway automatically reduced famine or improved peasant welfare: transport capacity does not guarantee equitable purchasing power or relief policy. A sound answer combines a map of routes with evidence of tariffs, freight, regional markets and employment. The published date of a line's opening should be distinguished from the year construction began or a guarantee agreement was signed.

## 11. Singareni: from mineral discovery to corporate ownership

The official Singareni Collieries Company history records coal discovery near Yellandu by Geological Survey of India geologist Dr King in 1871, mining rights acquired by the Hyderabad (Deccan) Company in 1886, and the incorporation of Singareni Collieries Company Limited on 23 December 1920. It also records the Hyderabad State's purchase of majority shares in 1945. These dates describe discovery, concession, corporate formation and ownership change, not one interchangeable “founding” event. A separate official commemoration identifies the beginning of coal mining in 1889.

Coal supported railways, industry and urban energy use, but production statistics alone cannot reveal workers' wages, injury risks, caste divisions or housing conditions. A mining town could generate employment while creating dependence on one employer and exposure to occupational hazards. Corporate history is valuable for organisational chronology; labour conditions require payrolls, accident reports, union records and oral testimony. For a Telangana-specific mains answer, connect geology and transport to industrialisation, then add the questions of ownership, labour, environment and the distribution of revenue. Never transfer present-day mine counts into the Nizam period.

## 12. The Musi flood and the political meaning of water infrastructure

The catastrophic Musi flood of 1908 made flood control and drinking-water provision urgent problems for Hyderabad city. The Telangana government's Ranga Reddy district page dates the creation of Osman Sagar, by damming the Musi, to 1920. The state's Musi Riverfront Development Corporation describes Osman Sagar and Himayat Sagar as reservoirs constructed during the Nizam period after the flood, while warning that their catchments now face degradation and encroachment. These official records establish the broad chronology and continued relevance of the infrastructure.

An urban history should go beyond celebrating engineering. Reservoirs required land, changed water flows, and could alter access for downstream users. Flood-control infrastructure might reduce one kind of risk while concentrating planning benefits in the city. A proper evaluation distinguishes design purpose, observed performance, maintenance and the social costs of construction. Modern catchment problems should not be retroactively presented as measured conditions in 1920. Use the flood-to-reservoir sequence as an example of a disaster reshaping public administration, then consider why preventive planning and equitable service distribution remain separate tests of effective governance.

## 13. Osmania University: Urdu-medium ambition and the access question

Osmania University's official history is unusually precise about its founding. A firman issued on 26 April 1917 authorised the institution and articulated a synthesis of eastern and western learning. The university identifies Urdu as the medium of instruction, with English compulsory as a language. Its milestones record the opening of arts and science colleges in 1918 and the later growth of professional education. A serious account distinguishes the royal charter, the commencement of classes and the construction of its permanent campus.

The Urdu-medium experiment was institutionally distinctive because it required translation, terminology development and teachers capable of explaining modern disciplines in that language. It also raised access questions in a multilingual state: Telugu-, Marathi- and Kannada-speaking students, especially from rural schools, did not automatically possess the same preparation in Urdu. Gender, caste, household income and the geography of secondary schools affected entry into higher education. Thus, the university was both an important project of intellectual modernisation and an institution embedded in uneven social opportunity. A mains answer should avoid either denying its achievements or treating the founding firman as proof of universal educational inclusion.

## 14. Industry and education must be assessed together

A catalogue of coal mines, textile enterprises, sugar production, railways, colleges and hospitals is not yet an explanation of development. Industrial investment depends on power, raw materials, transport, skilled labour and markets. Educational expansion may supply engineers, administrators and teachers, but the benefits depend on admission rules, language policy and the prior distribution of schooling. The same state that built modern institutions could retain rural structures that restricted mobility and political participation.

Consider two illustrative households: a railway employee in Secunderabad might obtain steady wages and urban schooling, while a tenant family in a distant village might still face debt and coercive labour demands. These are analytical examples, not documented household biographies. They show why aggregate institutional growth can coexist with unequal welfare. Historical assessment needs district-level literacy, enrolment, wages, tenancy and health data, ideally separated by sex and social group. In the absence of such records, make a bounded claim: infrastructure expanded and new occupations emerged, but distribution and social outcomes require further verification. This is stronger than inventing precise percentages.

## 15. Monuments as evidence of institutions, not just architectural style

The Asaf Jahi period left public buildings that expressed administrative, educational and civic priorities. Osmania University's Arts College, hospitals, courts, railway structures and urban public works should be studied as institutions as well as architectural objects. A building's stylistic vocabulary may combine local, Indo-Islamic and European influences; however, assigning a monument to a ruler requires checking design, construction and inauguration dates rather than relying on tourist captions.

A court building symbolises a legal bureaucracy, but its existence does not prove equal access to justice. A university building communicates intellectual ambition, but admissions and medium of instruction determine who could use it. A hospital may demonstrate public investment while leaving rural health gaps. Conservation also raises present-day questions: ownership, adaptive reuse, structural repair and the relationship between urban development and heritage protection. Students should pair each named monument with its historical function, patronage and social context. Avoid presenting unverified architectural attributions as established facts. The original building plans and public-works departmental files remain priority evidence for academic audit.

## 16. Telangana, Hyderabad State and the risk of geographic substitution

Hyderabad State included Telugu-, Marathi- and Kannada-speaking regions; the Telangana of today's state boundaries is not identical to the princely state of the nineteenth century. A Hyderabad State figure for revenue, population or schooling cannot be labelled a Telangana figure without district disaggregation. Even within Telugu-speaking districts, Hyderabad city, mining belts and agrarian interiors had different opportunities and constraints. This matters when comparing railway access, schooling, industrial employment and forms of land tenure.

The 2010 Committee for Consultations on the Situation in Andhra Pradesh report, hosted by India's Ministry of Home Affairs, describes Osmania University's early Urdu-medium system and the concentration of higher education in Hyderabad city, with limited provision outside it. That later report is retrospective evidence, not a nineteenth-century primary document. It is useful for framing an institutional disparity but should be triangulated with historical education reports. A precise mains answer states the geographical unit before interpreting any statistic. It then distinguishes an achievement of the princely government from the extent to which residents of rural Telangana actually benefited.

## 17. Three rival interpretations of Asaf Jahi modernisation

One interpretation emphasises state-building: Salar Jung's departmental reforms, railways, universities, reservoirs and hospitals increased administrative capacity and created modern professional institutions. A second foregrounds colonial dependency: military treaties and British financial influence constrained autonomy and shaped which investments were possible. A third examines society from below: jagirdari power, vetti, unequal education and the limits of political representation meant that institutional change did not transform every household's life.

These perspectives are not mutually exclusive. They ask different questions and use different evidence. State-building studies focus on official departments; imperial histories emphasise treaties and Residents; social histories investigate petitions, labour and village power. The strongest answer places all three in one causal account. British constraint and internal reform could operate simultaneously, while reforms could expand state capacity without dismantling local inequality. Reject both celebratory inevitability and a claim that no development occurred. Identify an institution, explain its mechanism, assess who gained, and specify which evidence is still missing. That is how historical interpretation becomes an argument rather than a sequence of names and dates.

## 18. Applied source criticism: an archival claim under examination

Suppose a study guide states: “The Nizam's railways modernised all of Telangana by 1874.” The statement fails three tests. First, 1874 identifies an early Wadi–Secunderabad connection, not a complete statewide network. Second, Hyderabad State and present-day Telangana are not the same geographical unit. Third, the existence of a line does not demonstrate equal access or rising living standards. A defensible revision is: “Rail connectivity expanded during the later nineteenth century, helping selected trade and administrative corridors; the distribution of benefits requires route, freight and district evidence.”

Apply the same method to education. “Osmania University was established in 1918” may refer to commencement, while its founding firman dates to 1917. Explain the event being dated. For mining, separate the 1871 geological discovery, the 1886 concession, commercial extraction and 1920 corporate incorporation. For 1857, distinguish a documented Residency attack from claims of a general state-wide rebellion. These corrections improve factual precision without pretending to possess missing archival records. They also train the examiner's preferred skills: chronology, causation, regional specificity and evaluation.

## Original explained practice MCQs — not official PYQs

### MCQ 1. Which evidence best establishes the wording of a Hyderabad–British treaty?

A. A later tourist brochure

B. A contemporary signed treaty or certified text

C. A monument inscription about a ruler

D. A modern textbook timeline

**Answer: B.** Treaty wording must be checked against an authentic text; secondary summaries can guide discovery but cannot replace the instrument.

### MCQ 2. The significance of Shakar Kheda in 1724 is best described as

A. The founding of Osmania University

B. The first railway opening

C. A decisive step toward autonomous Asaf Jahi authority

D. The abolition of jagirs

**Answer: C.** Asaf Jah I defeated Mubariz Khan, but Mughal legitimacy and Deccan negotiations continued.

### MCQ 3. Why should Hyderabad not be called an ordinary British province in 1857?

A. It had no British influence

B. The Nizam retained extensive internal government under paramountcy

C. It had no revenue departments

D. It was governed directly from Madras

**Answer: B.** The princely government retained internal administration despite constrained external sovereignty.

### MCQ 4. Which pair should be distinguished in Berar history?

A. Temple patronage and mining

B. Sovereign claim and administrative control

C. Urdu and Persian scripts

D. Canals and reservoirs

**Answer: B.** British management and the Nizam’s formal claims did not always align.

### MCQ 5. What is the strongest analytical distinction between jagirdar and deshmukh?

A. They always had identical legal rights

B. One refers to a category of grant while the other could derive power from revenue office and landholding

C. Both were elected ministers

D. Both were British district judges

**Answer: B.** Their rights and social influence had different and variable legal foundations.

### MCQ 6. What makes vetti different from merely low-paid labour?

A. The labour always occurred in mines

B. Its coercive character and inability to refuse freely

C. It was limited to one district

D. It involved only agricultural tax

**Answer: B.** Compulsion sustained by social and economic power is central to vetti.

### MCQ 7. Which evaluation of Salar Jung I is most defensible?

A. Every reform abolished rural inequality

B. Administrative capacity expanded, but social hierarchies persisted

C. He founded Osmania University in 1917

D. His reforms ended British paramountcy

**Answer: B.** Institutional reorganisation should be assessed separately from social distribution.

### MCQ 8. The Residency attack associated with Turre Baz Khan occurred in

A. 1724

B. 1853

C. 17 July 1857

D. 1918

**Answer: C.** The Hyderabad episode occurred in July 1857, despite the Nizam government's alignment with Britain.

### MCQ 9. Why is it misleading to call the Residency attack a statewide takeover?

A. It was a British victory in Bengal

B. The attempt did not displace the Nizam government

C. It took place after independence

D. It was conducted by a railway company

**Answer: B.** A significant local act of resistance should not be inflated into a successful territorial revolution.

### MCQ 10. Osmania University's official history dates its founding firman to

A. 26 April 1917

B. 23 December 1920

C. 17 July 1857

D. 9 October 1874

**Answer: A.** The official university history gives 26 April 1917; classes and colleges followed.

### MCQ 11. What does the year 1918 chiefly signify in Osmania University's milestones?

A. Its first royal charter

B. Opening of university colleges

C. Opening of the Wadi railway

D. The 1908 flood

**Answer: B.** The charter and operational beginning are distinct chronological milestones.

### MCQ 12. Which evidence would best test rural access to Osmania University?

A. The university building façade

B. District-level prior schooling, admission and language data

C. A royal portrait

D. The name of a campus road

**Answer: B.** Institutional creation alone does not prove equitable access.

### MCQ 13. Which railway connection is conventionally associated with 1874?

A. Wadi–Secunderabad

B. Delhi–Kolkata metro

C. Hyderabad–Mumbai bullet train

D. Nizamabad airport

**Answer: A.** The Wadi–Secunderabad line linked Hyderabad to wider railway systems.

### MCQ 14. Why can railway expansion coexist with rural inequality?

A. All goods travel without cost

B. Routes and purchasing power distribute benefits unevenly

C. Railways prohibit urban industry

D. Transport abolishes land tenure

**Answer: B.** Network access and economic gains are geographically and socially uneven.

### MCQ 15. The official SCCL history dates coal discovery near Yellandu by Dr King to

A. 1871

B. 1920

C. 1945

D. 1956

**Answer: A.** The company distinguishes geological discovery from later mining and incorporation.

### MCQ 16. The Singareni Collieries Company was incorporated on

A. 26 April 1917

B. 23 December 1920

C. 17 July 1857

D. 15 August 1947

**Answer: B.** The company’s official corporate history gives 23 December 1920.

### MCQ 17. Hyderabad State purchased majority shares of SCCL in

A. 1886

B. 1908

C. 1945

D. 1960

**Answer: C.** The company history records a 1945 ownership change, distinct from its 1920 incorporation.

### MCQ 18. Which event precipitated Hyderabad’s major twentieth-century flood-control initiatives?

A. The Musi flood of 1908

B. Shakar Kheda in 1724

C. The 1853 Berar agreement

D. The 1920 incorporation of SCCL

**Answer: A.** The flood shaped later reservoirs and urban planning.

### MCQ 19. The Telangana district government dates Osman Sagar's creation to

A. 1857

B. 1874

C. 1920

D. 1948

**Answer: C.** Its official description associates the reservoir with the post-1908 flood response.

### MCQ 20. Which conclusion about Osman Sagar requires separate evidence?

A. It was built after the Musi flood

B. It served drinking-water and flood-management purposes

C. Every downstream household benefited equally

D. It was built in the Nizam period

**Answer: C.** Distributional claims need records of land, water access and social effects.

### MCQ 21. Which best describes British Library record IOR/L/PS/18/D8?

A. An indexed catalogue record of treaties with Hyderabad

B. A verified Turre Baz Khan eyewitness diary

C. An Osmania student register

D. A railway timetable

**Answer: A.** The archive catalogue identifies the treaty file; catalogue access is not equivalent to reading each treaty clause.

### MCQ 22. Why should Hyderabad State statistics not automatically be called Telangana statistics?

A. The state included multiple linguistic regions

B. Telangana did not have villages

C. All Hyderabad statistics were false

D. The Nizam ruled only Hyderabad city

**Answer: A.** The geographical units are not identical; district disaggregation is necessary.

### MCQ 23. Which source would best test conditions of Singareni miners?

A. Only a company anniversary note

B. Wage registers, accident reports and worker testimony

C. A palace photograph

D. A treaty about Berar

**Answer: B.** Company histories establish chronology but cannot alone establish labour conditions.

### MCQ 24. Which interpretation foregrounds military finance and the Resident?

A. Ecological determinism

B. British paramountcy and imperial dependency

C. Pure architectural formalism

D. Only devotional history

**Answer: B.** Treaties, military costs and Residents are central to imperial-power analysis.

### MCQ 25. A university firman most directly proves

A. Universal enrolment

B. An institutional decision and stated aims

C. Equal female literacy

D. All districts had colleges

**Answer: B.** A proclamation establishes an initiative, not its distributional outcome.

### MCQ 26. A deshmukh’s influence could combine

A. Only electoral votes

B. Office, land, credit and patronage

C. Only military rank

D. Only religious office

**Answer: B.** Local power was often composite rather than a single tenure category.

### MCQ 27. What is the best way to date a historic public building?

A. Use a single tourist caption

B. Separate design, construction, opening and later reuse

C. Assume the reigning ruler personally designed it

D. Copy a nearby building’s date

**Answer: B.** Multiple milestones can be valid but refer to different events.

### MCQ 28. Which item is a retrospective source rather than a contemporary Nizam-era record?

A. A 2010 MHA-hosted committee report

B. An 1853 treaty instrument

C. A 1917 university firman

D. A 1920 corporate incorporation document

**Answer: A.** The committee report can contextualise educational disparity but is not contemporary to early Hyderabad rule.

### MCQ 29. What makes a claim about statewide railway benefits weak?

A. It specifies the route

B. It omits regional distribution and social access

C. It distinguishes construction and opening

D. It cites a timetable

**Answer: B.** Claims of universal benefits require geographical and economic evidence.

### MCQ 30. Which is the strongest overall conclusion on Asaf Jahi modernisation?

A. No meaningful institutions were built

B. Modern institutions expanded under constraints while inequality persisted

C. All subjects became politically equal

D. British paramountcy prevented any internal administration

**Answer: B.** State-building, imperial dependency and unequal social experience coexisted.

## Six structured original mains model answers (not official PYQs)

### Mains 1. Analyse the changing nature of British paramountcy over Hyderabad and its impact on internal reform.

**Background.** Hyderabad emerged from Mughal Deccan politics and developed considerable internal autonomy, but its external position changed as the East India Company became the dominant regional military power. Paramountcy was therefore a historical process, not a single permanent constitutional formula.

**Instruments of control.** Agreements associated with 1798 and 1800 expanded military dependence and constrained independent diplomacy. The British Resident mediated political relations, while the Hyderabad Contingent imposed costs that could become instruments of leverage. The 1853 Berar arrangement illustrates the connection between military finance and territorial administration. Legal claims and practical control must be distinguished rather than compressed into the word annexation.

**Continuing internal authority.** The Nizam's government retained substantial powers over revenue, departments, education and public works. Salar Jung I could reorganise administration even while imperial constraints remained. Later railways, educational institutions and water infrastructure similarly developed within a dependent princely framework.

**Critical assessment.** Official treaty collections illuminate imperial power, but do not alone reveal how ordinary cultivators experienced taxation or village authority. Rural petitions and district reports are necessary to assess that dimension.

**Conclusion.** British paramountcy reduced strategic sovereignty without erasing internal state-building. Hyderabad's history is best understood as constrained autonomy, combining reformist initiatives, fiscal dependence and persistent inequalities.

### Mains 2. Explain why Salar Jung I’s administrative reforms did not automatically eliminate jagirdari and vetti.

**Background.** Salar Jung I served as Diwan from 1853 to 1883 during a period of fiscal stress, fragmented administrative authority and British pressure. His reforms sought a more regular state machinery rather than an immediate social revolution.

**Administrative objectives.** Reorganisation of departments, district administration, accounts, policing, courts and communications strengthened the government's capacity to record revenue and coordinate officials. More predictable procedures could reduce some dependence on informal court networks. These changes created opportunities for salaried employment and later public institutions.

**Rural power.** Jagir assignments, deshmukh influence, land ownership, credit and village offices operated through overlapping relations. A cultivator might confront the same powerful family as landlord, lender and intermediary. Rewriting departmental rules did not necessarily remove that dependence. Vetti added coercive labour demands whose enforcement depended on local hierarchy, not simply formal revenue categories.

**Evaluation.** State capacity and social inclusion are separate outcomes. More efficient assessment could increase public revenue without guaranteeing security of tenure or the freedom to refuse unpaid labour. Evidence from petitions, village accounts and tenancy disputes is needed to evaluate local results.

**Conclusion.** Salar Jung's reforms were consequential institutional modernisation, but they did not by themselves dismantle agrarian domination. The unresolved contradictions later became central to Telangana's social and peasant movements.

### Mains 3. Assess the historical significance of Turre Baz Khan and the Hyderabad Residency attack in 1857.

**Background.** The uprising of 1857 affected regions under direct Company administration and princely states in different ways. Hyderabad was governed by the Nizam under British paramountcy, making its political choices especially complex.

**State position.** The Nizam's government and Salar Jung I supported the British. Military dependency, concern for internal stability and existing treaty obligations shaped that decision. It would nevertheless be wrong to treat the court's policy as the unanimous opinion of Hyderabad's inhabitants.

**Resistance.** On 17 July 1857, an armed group associated with Turre Baz Khan and Maulvi Alauddin attacked the British Residency. The attempt failed to dislodge British authority or overthrow the princely government. Its importance lies in the existence of organised local dissent despite official cooperation. The episode connected Hyderabad to the wider upheaval without reproducing the scale or pattern of north Indian rebellions.

**Historical method.** Residency correspondence, later biographies and commemorative accounts answer different questions. Exact participant numbers and dramatic quotations should not be asserted without contemporary verification. Popular memory deserves attention, but it cannot substitute for an original operational record.

**Conclusion.** Turre Baz Khan represents a significant strand of anti-colonial resistance in Telangana's historical memory. The episode reveals divided political loyalties within princely Hyderabad and the need to distinguish local action from claims of a statewide revolution.

### Mains 4. Evaluate railways and coal mining as instruments of economic change in the Nizam period.

**Background.** Railways and coal were mutually reinforcing components of Hyderabad's nineteenth- and twentieth-century economy. Their impact depended on geography, finance, ownership and labour relations rather than technology alone.

**Transport linkages.** The Wadi–Secunderabad connection opened in the 1870s and tied Hyderabad to wider railway networks. Railways facilitated military movement, administration, trade and the transport of minerals. Financing and guaranteed returns, however, could expose the state to fiscal commitments while routes concentrated benefits along selected corridors.

**Coal chronology.** The official Singareni company history distinguishes the discovery of coal near Yellandu in 1871, mining rights acquired in 1886, corporate incorporation on 23 December 1920 and the Hyderabad State's majority-share purchase in 1945. These are separate historical milestones. Coal created industrial and railway linkages, but also required demanding labour and settlement systems.

**Social limits.** A station or mine could generate wages and markets without guaranteeing gains for distant tenant farmers. Transport prices, employment contracts and market intermediaries determined who captured the gains. Company histories establish organisational facts; wage records, accident registers and worker accounts are needed to judge working conditions.

**Conclusion.** Railways and mining widened Hyderabad's economic possibilities but distributed opportunities unevenly. A balanced assessment joins infrastructure history with the political economy of labour, state finance and regional access.

### Mains 5. Explain Osmania University’s historical importance while assessing the limits of educational inclusion.

**Background.** The seventh Nizam's government founded Osmania University as an ambitious experiment in higher education and language policy. Its history requires distinguishing founding authority from the later opening of classes.

**Institutional innovation.** The university's official history dates the firman to 26 April 1917, while its milestones record arts and science colleges in 1918. Urdu became the medium of instruction, with English compulsory as a language. Translation, technical terminology and professional teaching became central to the project. Later programmes in medicine, engineering and other fields widened the university's institutional reach.

**Access and inequality.** Hyderabad State was multilingual. Telugu-, Marathi- and Kannada-speaking students did not necessarily have equivalent preparation in Urdu. Secondary-school availability, household resources, caste, gender and distance from Hyderabad city shaped entry into higher education. A royal charter demonstrates state intention, not universal enrolment or equal completion rates.

**Historical significance.** The institution trained new professionals and symbolised an attempt to connect local language, intellectual autonomy and modern disciplines. Yet district-level schooling and admission records are needed before measuring its social reach.

**Conclusion.** Osmania University was a distinctive achievement of Asaf Jahi modernisation. Its importance is strengthened, not diminished, by evaluating the educational opportunities it created alongside the barriers that many rural and disadvantaged students continued to face.

### Mains 6. Was modernisation under the sixth and seventh Nizams socially inclusive? Discuss with examples.

**Background.** The later Asaf Jahi period witnessed substantial institutional growth. Modernisation should be judged not only by new buildings and technologies but also by who could use them and under what conditions.

**Achievements.** Railway links expanded commerce and administrative reach. Singareni coal contributed to industry and transport. After the Musi flood of 1908, reservoirs such as Osman Sagar supported water supply and flood management. Osmania University's 1917 founding firman and subsequent teaching institutions represented an important educational initiative. Public buildings, hospitals and professional offices reflected a more complex urban state.

**Unequal outcomes.** Hyderabad city and connected industrial corridors enjoyed opportunities unavailable to many agrarian villages. Jagirdari and deshmukh influence, debt, insecure tenancy and vetti could continue alongside new public works. Urdu-medium higher education was innovative but access depended on earlier schooling, language, caste, gender and income. Industrial jobs also introduced occupational hazards and employer dependence.

**Evidence needed.** Administrative histories document projects; district-level literacy, wages, health, land tenure and school admissions would establish their distribution. Hyderabad State totals cannot automatically be substituted for present-day Telangana figures.

**Conclusion.** The sixth and seventh Nizams presided over real institutional modernisation, but its benefits were socially and geographically uneven. State capacity expanded more rapidly than political equality and rural economic security.

## Dated source and evidence audit (editorial transparency)

1. **26 October 2026 checked — Official commission syllabus clause:** TGPSC Group-I syllabus, Paper II Unit II Item 3. Official/catalogue URL: websitenew.tspsc.gov.in Scope corroborated with repository transcription; original 2024 notification text previously directly verified for neighbouring item; fresh direct 2024 PDF review pending.

2. **1864 original; catalogue checked 26 Oct 2026 — Contemporary treaty compilation, metadata:** C. U. Aitchison, Collection of Treaties, Vol V (1864). Official/catalogue URL: granthsanjeevani.com Digitisation metadata verified; treaty clauses not read directly in this run.

3. **1759–1861 collection; catalogue checked 26 Oct 2026 — Archival catalogue:** British Library IOR/L/PS/18/D8 Treaties with Hyderabad. Official/catalogue URL: searcharchives.bl.uk Catalogue confirms 33-page file; no full manuscript inspection.

4. **26 April 1917; checked 26 Oct 2026 — Institutional official history:** Osmania University founding firman. Official/catalogue URL: www.osmania.ac.in Institutional narrative corroborates founding firman and Urdu/English policy; original signed firman not inspected.

5. **1918; checked 26 Oct 2026 — Institutional official milestones:** Osmania University milestones. Official/catalogue URL: www.osmania.ac.in Separates university colleges opening from 1917 founding.

6. **1871; checked 26 Oct 2026 — Corporate official history:** Singareni Collieries Company, History. Official/catalogue URL: scclmines.com Discovery of Yellandu coal by Dr King; corporate retrospective, not original GSI field book.

7. **1886; checked 26 Oct 2026 — Corporate official history:** Singareni Collieries Company, History. Official/catalogue URL: scclmines.com Hyderabad (Deccan) Company acquisition of mining rights.

8. **1889; checked 26 Oct 2026 — Corporate official commemoration:** SCCL foundation commemoration. Official/catalogue URL: scclmines.com Corporate statement about mining commencement; original mine registers pending.

9. **23 December 1920; checked 26 Oct 2026 — Corporate official history:** Singareni Collieries Company, History. Official/catalogue URL: scclmines.com Date of corporate incorporation distinguished from mining commencement.

10. **1945; checked 26 Oct 2026 — Corporate official history:** Singareni Collieries Company, History. Official/catalogue URL: scclmines.com Hyderabad State majority-share acquisition.

11. **1908 and 1920; checked 26 Oct 2026 — Government district heritage description:** Ranga Reddy District: Osman Sagar. Official/catalogue URL: rangareddy.telangana.gov.in Government retrospective connects reservoir with 1908 Musi flood and dates creation to 1920.

12. **1908; checked 26 Oct 2026 — Government water-infrastructure overview:** Musi Riverfront Development Corporation. Official/catalogue URL: musi.telangana.gov.in Reservoirs constructed following flood; modern catchment context not retrojected.

13. **2010 report; checked 26 Oct 2026 — Later official committee report:** MHA Committee for Consultations on Situation in Andhra Pradesh. Official/catalogue URL: www.mha.gov.in Retrospective educational context; not contemporary princely-era primary source.

14. **1857; archival originals outstanding — Unverified primary document target:** Hyderabad Residency 1857 correspondence and Turre Baz Khan trial/police records. Not obtained; avoid precise force numbers and quotations.

15. **1853; archival originals outstanding — Unverified primary document target:** Original Hyderabad Contingent and Berar agreement instruments. Indexed in treaty collections but individual signed instruments not examined.

16. **Late 19th–early 20th centuries; originals outstanding — Unverified primary document target:** Hyderabad State administrative, revenue and education reports. Needed for district-level tenancy, literacy, labour and welfare claims.

## Applied Telangana case exercises

**Case A — Tenant record:** A deshmukh family controls credit and influences village records. Identify legal tenure, practical land control, coercive capacity and the independent appeal route before proposing reform.

**Case B — Mining labour:** Compare an official SCCL corporate milestone with a worker accident register. Explain why company chronology does not measure occupational welfare.

**Case C — Urdu-medium admissions:** A rural Telugu-speaking student seeks university admission in 1925. Assess the prior-schooling, language and economic barriers without assuming every student faced identical obstacles.

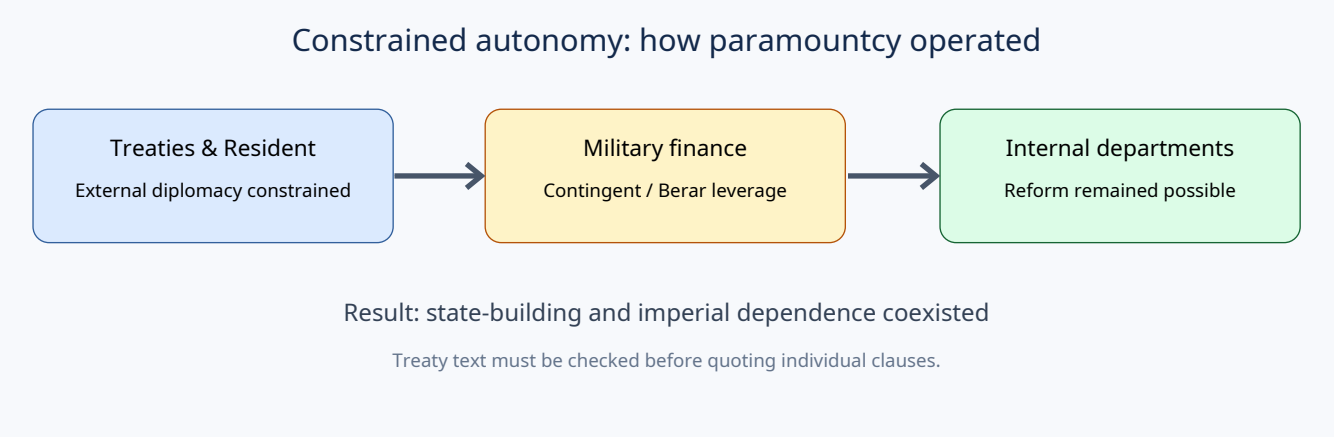
**Case D — Railway corridor:** Two villages lie at different distances from a station. Analyse likely market access and what freight, price and road data would be required to establish benefit.

**Case E — Flood mitigation:** A new reservoir protects the city but changes downstream flows. Identify the public-health, environmental and distributional questions that an official project summary may omit.

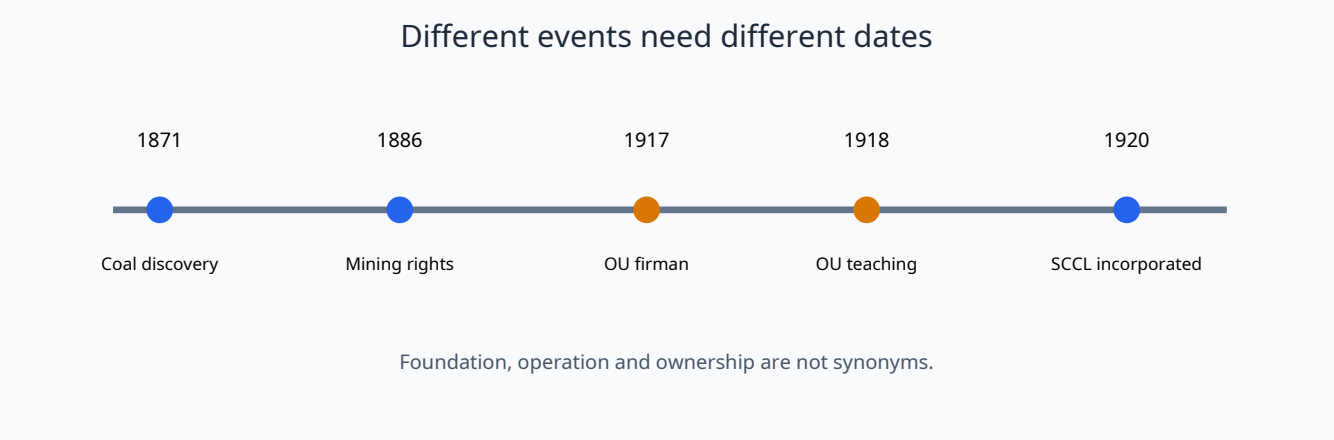
**Case F — Archival fact check:** A guide claims that 1857 Hyderabad was a successful statewide revolt. Separate contemporaneous state policy, documented Residency resistance, the outcome and later memorialisation.

## Three original analytical diagrams

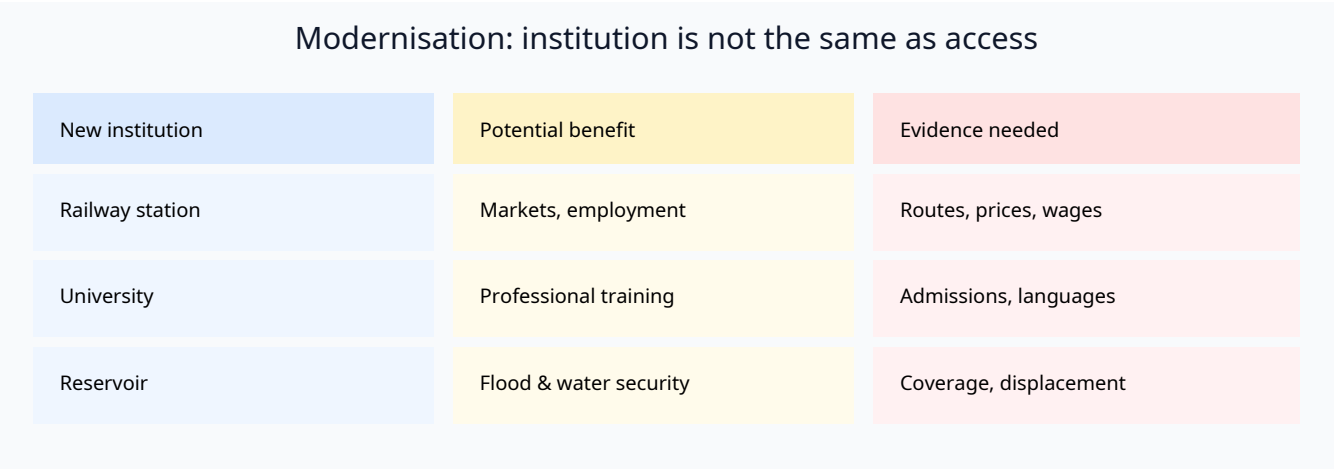
### Paramountcy




### Milestones




### Uneven Development




1. Treaty and state-capacity mechanism — sovereignty and fiscal leverage.
2. Evidence chronology — distinguish foundation, operation and ownership milestones.
3. Uneven modernisation matrix — institutions, benefits and evidence gaps.

## Archival cross-examination: five claims that need qualification

**Claim 1: “The 1798 treaty ended Hyderabad sovereignty.”** The proposition collapses external diplomatic constraint into the abolition of all internal government. The treaty series and subsequent administration show a more layered relationship. Verify each treaty provision in the signed instrument or critical edition before quoting its exact words; the archive catalogue is only a discovery aid.

**Claim 2: “Berar was simply annexed in 1853.”** This erases the distinction between formal claims and British management linked to the Hyderabad Contingent. A correct reconstruction requires the 1853 agreement, later instruments and contemporary maps. It must also avoid equating Berar with Telugu-speaking Telangana.

**Claim 3: “Salar Jung abolished village oppression.”** Departmental restructuring could improve accounts and police organisation without automatically changing who controlled credit, land records or labour. An archival audit should compare revenue circulars with tenancy disputes, petitions and evidence of compulsory service. If village-level records are missing, do not claim universal emancipation.

**Claim 4: “Osmania University was founded in 1918, not 1917.”** The official university records distinguish the founding firman of 26 April 1917 from the start of colleges in 1918. Historians must specify which milestone is meant. The next question concerns access: the number of courses cannot substitute for admissions by district, language, caste and gender.

**Claim 5: “Singareni began in 1920.”** The corporate history distinguishes discovery in 1871, acquisition of rights in 1886, mining from 1889, company incorporation in 1920 and Hyderabad State majority ownership in 1945. Each event belongs to a different kind of evidence. A mining-company history does not independently verify miners' working conditions.

The discipline connecting these examples is **source-specific precision**: date the event being discussed, define the geographical unit, separate institutional intention from measured outcome, and identify the missing record before making a stronger claim. This approach produces better history and more defensible mains answers than adding unverified names or percentages.

## Academic quality gate

**Not approved.** The 1864 treaty volume and British Library catalogue were located, but individual signed treaties were not read. The university and mining-company histories are institutional retrospectives, not the founding instruments or contemporaneous mine registers. Full archival material for the Residency attack, Salar Jung's district reports and village-level vetti evidence remains outstanding. No practice question is labelled an official PYQ. Independent expert review has not occurred.